

Ohio Housing Accountability and Revitalization Program (OHARP)

OHARP will serve as a statewide initiative aimed at addressing vacant, abandoned, and poorly managed rental properties while improving housing stability and revitalizing communities. Here's a detailed breakdown of how the program could be structured:

1. Local Agent Requirement (Modeled after Cleveland's 'Residents First')

- **Goal:** Ensure absentee landlords are held accountable for maintaining their properties.
- **Key Components:**
 - **Local Agent Mandate:** Any landlord who lives outside Ohio or in a non-adjacent county must appoint a local agent to oversee the property. This agent must reside within the state and will assume responsibility for code violations and other management issues.
 - **Annual Registration:** Require all rental property owners to register annually with the state, providing details on the property's occupancy and the appointed local agent.
 - **Enforcement:** Landlords or their local agents will face penalties for failing to comply with the housing code. Penalties could include fines, property liens, or being barred from renting until issues are resolved.

2. Vacancy Tax for Empty or Abandoned Properties

- **Goal:** Discourage speculative holding of vacant properties and promote their active use.
- **Key Components:**
 - **Vacancy Definition:** Properties would be considered "vacant" if they remain unoccupied for six consecutive months without reasonable attempts to rent, sell, or renovate.
 - **Tax Structure:** After the six-month threshold, properties would be subject to an annual tax. The tax rate could be determined based on the property's value, with potential increases for prolonged vacancy (e.g., 1% for year one, 2% for year two).
 - **Exemptions:** Properties actively listed for sale or undergoing permitted renovations could be exempt from the vacancy tax.
 - **Revenue Allocation:** Tax revenue would be funneled into local affordable housing programs, homelessness prevention initiatives, and grants to rehabilitate blighted properties.

3. Affordable Housing Incentives

- **Goal:** Increase the availability of affordable housing, especially in areas with high vacancy rates.

- **Key Components:**
 - **Tax Credits for Developers:** Provide tax credits to developers who convert vacant properties into affordable housing units or undertake rehabilitation projects in blighted areas.
 - **Rental Assistance Programs:** Use vacancy tax revenue to fund rental assistance for low-income families, ensuring that renovated or newly developed properties remain affordable.
 - **Public-Private Partnerships:** Work with local businesses, nonprofits, and community development agencies to turn vacant properties into housing solutions for at-risk populations, including low-income families and the homeless.

4. Community Revitalization Initiatives

- **Goal:** Encourage the repurposing of vacant or abandoned properties for community use.
- **Key Components:**
 - **Community Land Trusts (CLTs):** Support the establishment of CLTs, which allow local communities to purchase vacant properties and use them for affordable housing, community centers, or green spaces.
 - **Small Business Grants:** Offer small business grants to entrepreneurs and organizations that propose sustainable uses for long-term vacant properties, such as affordable housing, coworking spaces, or community-driven projects.
 - **Historic Preservation Grants:** Allocate funds for rehabilitating historically significant but vacant properties, ensuring their preservation while contributing to community revitalization.

5. Enforcement and Compliance

- **Goal:** Ensure robust enforcement of housing and vacancy regulations across the state.
- **Key Components:**
 - **Statewide Rental Registry:** Create a centralized system for tracking the occupancy status and code compliance of rental properties across Ohio. This registry would help enforce both the local agent requirement and the vacancy tax.
 - **Fines and Penalties:** Impose fines on landlords who fail to comply with either the local agent requirement or vacancy tax. Repeat offenders could face more severe penalties, including the seizure of property in extreme cases.
 - **Housing Court:** Strengthen the role of housing courts across Ohio, empowering them to take swift action against negligent landlords and ensure properties meet livability standards.

6. Funding and Budgeting

- **Goal:** Secure sustainable funding for OHARP.
- **Key Components:**

- **Vacancy Tax Revenue:** As mentioned, revenue from the special property tax on vacant homes would provide a steady funding stream for housing initiatives, including affordable housing development and homelessness prevention.
 - **State Budget Allocations:** Advocate for state funding to support the initial startup costs of OHARP, particularly in setting up the rental registry, local agent oversight, and code enforcement infrastructure.
 - **Federal Grants:** Pursue federal housing and community development grants to supplement state and local funding, particularly for projects related to affordable housing and homelessness.
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Key Benefits of OHARP

- **Improved Housing Conditions:** Ensuring that absentee landlords are held accountable will improve the quality of rental housing across the state.
- **Affordable Housing Supply:** Vacant properties will be reintroduced into the housing market, either as affordable rental units or community spaces.
- **Community Revitalization:** Ohio's neighborhoods will see a decrease in abandoned properties, leading to safer, more vibrant communities.
- **Homelessness Prevention:** By transforming vacant properties into affordable housing, OHARP will help alleviate housing instability and reduce homelessness.